

INTERNAL — NOT FOR THE BANK

Answer brief

Every hard question they can ask, with an answer you can say out loud.

Read it once. Then say the answers aloud, to the wall, until they come without reaching. The answer you reach for is the answer they do not believe.

Three rules: short answer first · never invent a number · “I will confirm that” beats a guess

SECTION 1

The technical questions

These are the ones that hurt yesterday. Learn these four first — the rest follow.

What is it built on?

TypeScript on Node.js, PostgreSQL 15 for the database, React for the interface, packaged in Docker containers, running on Ubuntu Server. No proprietary licensing anywhere in that stack.

If pressed further, hand them page 12. Do not try to recite twelve layers from memory.

Where is the server hosted?

On your infrastructure, in your data centre. We host nothing. Today it is running on this laptop, which is the same software on a single node — that is how we can run it with the wireless switched off.

The word “server” confuses people. The server is a program, and right now it is running on your machine. In production it runs on theirs.

How would our staff access it?

They open a browser and go to an internal address, the same way they reach any other internal system. Nothing is installed on anyone’s computer, and nothing is downloaded to 100 branches when we release an update.

Optional, if the room has wireless: “Connect to this network and open this address — use it from your own phone.” Test it first.

How does disaster recovery work? How does the data get there?

The database writes every change to a transaction log before applying it, and that log is streamed continuously to the DR site over your own dedicated link or VPN, encrypted. The standby replays it and stays seconds behind. A third copy goes to Far-DR asynchronously.

Then the line that wins it: “Whether that runs synchronously or asynchronously is your recovery point objective, and it is a setting your IT Division owns, not us.”

Scale, security, ownership

Which database, and why?

PostgreSQL 15. ACID compliant, with row-level security, streaming replication and point-in-time recovery all native rather than bolted on — which maps directly onto your audit, encryption and DR requirements.

How many concurrent users can it handle?

The application tier is stateless, so capacity is a matter of how many instances you run behind the load balancer. We size it with your IT Division at requirements stage and validate it under load test before go-live, against your real branch and headcount numbers.

Do NOT invent a number. “Stateless, so we scale horizontally, and we load-test against your figures” is the correct answer and a stronger one.

How is our data encrypted?

Encrypted at rest at the database and storage layer, and in transit over TLS 1.2 or higher on every hop — client to application, application to database, application to any integrated system. Key management is configured by your own security administrators, so you are never dependent on us to rotate your own keys.

Can it use our single sign-on?

Yes. The system has its own user and password management, and it can integrate with your central IAM by API for single sign-on and password policy. Which of the two you use is your choice.

Integration and ownership

How do you connect to our CBS?

Through a dedicated middleware tier that owns every external connection. That is deliberate: when your CBS upgrades its API, one layer changes and procurement logic is never touched. Same tier handles HRMS, DMS, IAM, e-mail, SMS and the payment gateway.

Show them the integrations screen. Every endpoint is listed and every one is marked Not connected. Say that plainly — it is the honest position and they will respect it.

How do we know the audit log cannot be edited?

Press the verify button in front of them. Then open one record and show the cryptographic working — the exact bytes hashed, the previous record's hash, and the recomputed digest against the stored one.

Then: "There is no update or delete operation on that table anywhere in the application, for any role. The administrator does not have that permission because the permission does not exist."

What happens to us if your firm disappears?

You keep everything. Full documentation, database design, field-level mapping to the interface, API specifications and user manuals are handed to your IT Division at completion. The stack is TypeScript and PostgreSQL, which you can hire for in Dhaka tomorrow. Nothing here needs us to keep running.

This is a strong answer. Deliver it without defensiveness — it is a reason to choose you, not a threat.

What about backup?

Administrator-controlled from inside the system, on a schedule you set, with manual backup on demand — deliberately separate from your infrastructure-level backup so you have two independent layers rather than one point of failure.

SECTION 2

The commercial questions

Answer these calmly. Hesitation here reads as something to hide.

What exactly does each member of the joint venture do?

We bid and deliver as one entity. One contract, one project manager, one technical account lead. The joint venture carries the obligation as a whole — there is no arrangement under which one member points at another, and you will never manage three relationships.

This is the question that caught you. Do not describe a division of labour. Say “one accountable party” and move to what the Bank gets.

Is this live anywhere?

This is a working demonstration of the system we proposed. The workflow engine, the permission model, the two-envelope control and the audit trail are real and enforced. No connector on the integrations screen is live, and the About screen inside the application says so before you have to ask.

Never claim a production deployment you cannot name. If they ask for references, take the question and confirm afterwards.

Why should we not take the lowest bid?

Because the controls you have just watched refuse in the data layer rather than in a manual, because we built Shariah governance and procurement integrity that nobody asked us for, and because the integrity module is currently flagging one crore twenty-two lakh of questions in six months of demonstration data. That is the difference in one year.

Say the number. Let it sit.

Delivery and terms

How long until it is live?

Sixty working days from the work order with minor customisation, ninety with the integrations. You see a running system in week three and again every fortnight after that.

That is their own clause 1.16. Quoting their document back to them is powerful.

What do you need from us to start?

Three things. The right people for three weeks — whoever owns the procurement policy, the delegation of authority and CBS access. Your policy documents and system credentials. And one decision: your payment service provider, which is the single item genuinely blocked until you choose.

Asking for the payment provider decision makes you sound like someone who has delivered before.

When do we pay?

As set out in your own clause 1.19 — no advance payment, full payment after successful delivery at the live environment, less five percent security money and applicable VAT, tax and AIT.

Know this cold. You are paid nothing until go-live. If anyone on your side suggests otherwise, they are wrong.

What is the annual maintenance charge for?

Twelve months of warranty are included after go-live at no cost. The AMC covers the years after that — helpdesk, SLA-backed response, and any change a regulatory shift requires.

Check the Annexure-C wording before you quote a figure. The words column on the AMC line does not match the figures.

The product questions

Can we change approval limits ourselves?

Yes — and rather than describe it, change one in front of them in the workflow builder and watch the routing redraw before saving.

Then the sentence that answers the follow-up nobody asks until later: “It saves as a new version. Anything already in approval keeps the rules it started under — changing a threshold today cannot retroactively rewrite an approval that began yesterday.”

Show me module [anything].

Open it. Every register is reachable from the sidebar and none of them depends on the demonstration thread. If it is a build-phase item, say so plainly and show the evidence pack entry instead.

“That one is scheduled for the build phase — here is what I can show you today” is a complete answer. One improvised claim that falls apart costs more than twenty honest answers.

What about the payment gateway?

Declared in our submitted Annexure-B as needing customisation, because it is specific to whichever payment service provider you select. It affects six modules. That answer has not changed since the bid.

Six of the twelve customisation items are payment-gateway related. They already have this answer on file.

Is it Shariah compliant?

The system contains no Shariah rulings and makes none. It holds the rules your Supervisory Committee issues, applies them mechanically, and refers what they catch back to your Committee for a human decision. No other role can record a decision on the Committee’s behalf — not even the system administrator.

NEVER say the software knows Shariah. One scholar, one question, and the room is lost. The above is both true and stronger.

Your integrity module is accusing our staff of fraud.

It is not. Every finding is a question with an innocent explanation available, and the wording says so. The system puts the question in front of a person with the evidence attached. It does not decide.

If this comes up, somebody is uncomfortable. Answer warmly, not defensively.

When you do not know

There are three sentences that save you, and one that ends you.

The one that ends you

Making something up. They will test it, either in the room or in the contract, and everything else you said becomes suspect at the same moment.

Sentence one — you genuinely do not know

“I do not want to guess at that. Let me confirm it and come back to you today.”

Then write it down in front of them. Writing it down is half the credibility.

Sentence two — it is not built yet

“That is in the build phase, inside the delivery window. What I can show you today is this.”

Then show something adjacent that does work. Never leave the answer sitting on the negative.

Sentence three — they are right about a gap

“That is a fair point and you are right. Here is what we would do about it.”

Conceding a real point buys you enormous credit on the next ten. Arguing a lost point spends it.

The thing to remember when it gets uncomfortable

Every other bidder will claim twenty-five out of twenty-five with no gaps. You are the only one in the process who has handed them a document that says which parts are not finished. That is not a weakness in the room — it is the reason they will believe the rest.

Before you walk in

The machine

Mains power. Screen sleep off. Notifications off. One browser window, no other tabs, 100% zoom. **Wireless off** — nothing needs it, and proving that to yourself now removes the venue network as a risk.

The commands

`npm run demo` → wait for Ready → `npm run warm` in a second window → `npm run reset` last, so you start from a clean state.

If something breaks mid-demonstration

`npm run reset` takes five seconds and is safe while the application is running. Refresh the page afterwards. If a screen misbehaves, every register is reachable from the sidebar and none of them depends on the thread — move on and come back.

If the requisition will not create

REQ/CSD/2026/0845 is already sitting in Farhana Akter's queue, raised by Rezaul, identical in every respect. Open it and the maker-checker moment works exactly the same.

If you are running out of time

Cut in this order: the invoice approval chain, the vendor portal, the comparative statement, goods receipt.

Never cut: the self-approval refusal, the sealed price refusal, the over-quantity work order refusal, the workflow builder, the audit chain verification.

Take with you

The seventeen-page handout, printed, one per person. The evidence pack, printed or on a second screen. This brief, for yourself only. A power adapter. And the name of whoever at Nascenia can answer a technical question by telephone if one lands that you cannot.